

Second Brain Starter Kit

Turn any AI into a second brain — one that remembers what you learn, organizes it for you, and helps you decide what's worth your time.

A starter kit for people who are not technical.

Version 1.0 • User Manual

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How to use this manual

This manual has one job: get you from "I downloaded a folder" to "I have a working second brain" — without needing to understand a single line of code.

Two ways to read it:

- **Front to back.** If this is all new, read straight through. Each chapter builds on the one before it.
- **Jump in.** Already set up? Go straight to the chapter for the skill you want to use. Chapters 3, 4, and 5 each stand on their own.

What the boxes mean:

● Tip

A shortcut or a way to do something better.

● Heads up

Something to avoid, or a common mistake.

● Example

A real, copy-paste-ready example.

● Good to know

Extra context you can skip if you're in a hurry.

The one rule:

You do not have to be technical. You will not edit code. You will *talk* to your AI in plain language — in English or Spanish — and it does the work. If a step ever feels like programming, you're overthinking it. Just say what you want.

● About the language

Everything in this kit works in **English and Spanish**. This is the English edition of the manual; a full Spanish edition ships alongside it. You can speak to your brain in whichever language you think in, regardless of which manual you're reading.

Introduction — What is a second brain?

Think about everything you've learned this year about running your work and your life. A pricing trick that finally stuck. The name of that supplier who came through in a pinch. A lesson from a job that went sideways. An idea for a new offer that hit you in the truck and was gone by lunch.

Where does all of that live right now?

For most people, the honest answer is: **nowhere reliable**. It's scattered across your memory, a few text messages, some screenshots, a notes app you never reopen, and a couple of napkins. It's a shoebox of receipts. The information is technically "saved," but you can't actually *use* it, because you can't find it when it matters.

A **second brain** fixes that. It's a single, organized place where the useful stuff you learn gets captured, sorted, and connected — so that six months from now, when you face a similar decision, your brain hands you exactly what you learned the last time.

● The simplest definition

A second brain is a place outside your head that remembers *for* you — and, with this kit, helps you *think* too.

What this kit actually is

This is **not** an app you have to learn. It's not a subscription. It's not a course.

It's a small folder of instructions that teaches the AI you already use — Claude, Cowork, Codex, Gemini, or another assistant — how to behave like a second brain. When you install it, your AI gains four new abilities (we call them **skills**), and it builds you an organized **vault**: a tidy set of folders where your knowledge will live.



The notes are plain text files. They open in any editor. They're yours forever, on your own computer or cloud drive. Nothing is locked inside someone else's software. If you ever stop using the kit, you keep every note.

● You don't need Obsidian to start

The kit organizes your notes for a free app called **Obsidian**, which gives you a beautiful map of how your ideas connect. But the notes are plain files — you can read them anywhere. Install Obsidian when you're ready; the brain works without it.

Who this is for

This kit was built for **busy people who are not technical** and who are tired of losing what they know:

- Business owners juggling jobs, crews, clients, and a hundred small decisions a day.
- Anyone learning a lot, fast — from books, courses, videos, or just doing the work.
- People who have *tried* note apps before and quit because keeping them organized felt like a second job.

Who it's NOT for: if you want a brain that runs automatically in the background without you, this isn't that (yet). This kit is for someone who's willing to spend 30 seconds at the end of a conversation saying "save this." That tiny habit is the whole engine.

● One honest expectation

A second brain is only as good as the habit behind it. The kit makes the habit almost effortless — but you still have to say "save it." Chapter 6 shows you how to make that automatic in your week.

The four skills, one line each

Skill	What it does for you
<code>second-brain-init</code>	Sets everything up the first time. You run it once.
<code>save-to-obsidian</code>	Captures what you learned and files it correctly.
<code>project-advisor</code>	Scores a new idea before you waste time on it.
<code>obsidian-power-user</code>	Quietly makes every note clean and connected.

The promise

Here's what you'll have by the end of this manual:

1. **A brain that's set up** — a vault on your computer, organized into clear sections, ready for knowledge.

2. **A capture habit** — the ability to end any conversation with "save to my brain" and trust that the good parts are kept.
3. **A decision filter** — a way to run any new idea through a quick, honest evaluation so you build the right things.
4. **A system that grows** — the more you use it, the more your brain knows you, and the better its help gets.

You don't have to do all of that today. You just have to do the next chapter: **set it up**.

- **How long will this take?**

Setup is about 10 minutes. Reading this manual is about an hour. Building the habit takes a week. After that, it just works.

Turn the page and let's set up your brain.

Chapter 1 — Setup & Install

This is the one technical-*feeling* chapter, and even this one isn't really technical. You'll copy a folder, say one sentence, and answer six questions. That's it. By the end, your brain exists.

Here's the whole chapter at a glance:

Step 1 — Copy the skills folder



Step 2 — Say: 'Set up my second brain'



Step 3 — Answer 6 questions



Step 4 — Your vault is built



Step 5 — Verify it worked ✓

What you need before you start

You need three things, and you probably already have the first one:

- 1. **An AI assistant that supports "skills."** This kit works in Claude (including Cowork), Codex, Gemini, and other assistants that read `SKILL.md` files. If you're reading this, you almost certainly have one.
- 2. **The kit folder** — the `skills/` folder that came with this manual.
- 3. **(Optional) Obsidian** — the free app from obsidian.md. You can install it now or later. The brain is built either way.

● **You do NOT need**

A developer. A paid subscription. A server. Any coding. Notion (it's optional). A perfect computer setup. If you can copy a folder and type a sentence, you can do this.

Step 1 — Copy the skills folder

Your AI assistant looks for skills in one specific folder on your computer. Installing the kit means copying the four skill folders into that location.

Find your assistant in the table below and use its folder:

Your assistant	Put the skills here
Claude Code / Cowork	<code>~/.claude/skills/</code>
Codex	<code>~/.codex/skills/</code>
Gemini CLI	<code>~/.gemini/skills/</code>
Other	Check your assistant's docs for "skills" or "agents," then use that folder.

If you're comfortable with the terminal, this one line does it (Claude/Cowork shown):

```
cp -r skills/* ~/.claude/skills/
```

If the terminal isn't your thing, that's fine — just **drag the four folders** (`second-brain-init` , `obsidian-power-user` , `save-to-obsidian` , `project-advisor`) into the skills folder using your file manager (Finder on Mac, Explorer on Windows).

● The `~`` symbol

- ~ is just shorthand for your home folder (e.g., `/Users/yourname` on a Mac). You don't have to type it
- your file manager opens there by default.

Step 2 — Say the magic sentence

Open a new conversation with your assistant and type:

"Set up my second brain."

That's the trigger. It wakes up the `second-brain-init` skill, which runs the whole setup for you. You don't have to say it perfectly — "I just installed the starter kit" works too.

● What's happening behind the scenes

The assistant noticed there's no brain set up yet (no `CLAUDE.md` config file), so it knows to run setup instead of guessing. This only happens once. After today, that same sentence won't restart anything — it'll just confirm you're already set up.

Step 3 — Answer six questions

Setup asks you six short questions, one at a time. There are no wrong answers, and you can change any of them later. Here's what it asks and why:

#	Question	Why it asks
1	What should I call you?	So the brain speaks to you by name.
2	What do you do? (optional)	So advice fits your work. Leave blank for personal use.
3	What do you want to call your brain?	The vault's name. e.g., "My Second Brain."
4	Where should it live?	iCloud/Dropbox to sync across devices, or just your Documents folder.
5	Which language by default?	English, Spanish, or both. You can switch any time.
6	Do you use Notion?	Optional. If yes, one skill can also copy results there. If no, everything stays in your vault.

● About Question 4 (where it lives)

If you want your brain on your phone *and* your computer, pick **iCloud** (Mac) or **Dropbox**. They sync automatically. If you only ever use one computer, the **Documents** folder is perfectly fine.

● About Question 6 (Notion)

If you don't already use Notion, just say **No**. It's an optional extra, not part of the core brain. Saying no makes nothing worse — everything still gets saved to your vault.

Step 4 — Your vault gets built

After your six answers, the brain creates your vault — a set of folders with clear names and numbers. You'll see it report each step as it goes ("Creating vault...", "Installing skills..."). Here's the shape it builds:

```
Your Brain/
├─ 00 Inbox/           ← when it doesn't fit anywhere else yet
├─ 01 Personal Knowledge/ ← people, places, routines, lessons
├─ 02 Strategy/        ← vision, goals, decisions, your "North Star"
├─ 03 Ideas & Notes/    ← ideas before they become projects
├─ 04 Learning/        ← books, courses, tech, business
├─ 05 AI System/       ← how your tools and skills fit together
├─ 06 Session Logs/    ← a record of every working session
├─ Templates/         ← reusable note shapes
└─ Excalidraw/        ← drawings and diagrams
```

Don't worry about memorizing this — Chapter 2 walks through every folder. For now, just know: it built you a filing cabinet, and every drawer has a label.

● If you already have an Obsidian vault

Setup is careful. If you point it at notes you already have, it **adds** the new sections alongside your existing notes — it never deletes or moves what's already there. Your old notes stay exactly where they are.

Step 5 — Verify it worked

When setup finishes, it runs three quick checks and shows you the results:

- ✓ Vault created
- ✓ obsidian-power-user installed
- ✓ save-to-obsidian installed
- ✓ project-advisor installed
- ✓ CLAUDE.md configured

If everything shows a green check, you're done — your brain is live. If anything shows a red **X**, the brain will walk you through the fix before calling setup complete. The most common cause is the skills folder landing in the wrong place; re-check Step 1's table for your assistant.

● What "done" looks like

The assistant gives you one short confirmation, the checklist above, and **exactly one** suggested next step — usually: "Have a normal conversation about something you're working on, then say 'save to my brain.'" That's your cue for Chapter 3.

What setup created for you

Two files matter enough to name now (Chapter 2 explains them fully):

- **CLAUDE.md** — your brain's settings file. It holds your name, your vault location, your language, and your trigger phrases. The assistant reads it at the start of every conversation so it always knows who you are.
- **CURRENT-CONTEXT.md** — a short, living summary of what you're working on right now. You'll update this about once a week. It's the first thing the brain reads to get oriented.

You don't need to open either one today. They're set up correctly out of the box.

● Your setup got saved too

The very first thing your brain did after setup was write a session log of the setup itself. So your brain's "birth certificate" is already in `06 Session Logs/`. That's the capture habit working before you even learned it.

A quick mental model

For the rest of this manual, hold this picture in your head:

- **You talk.** In plain language, in your language.
- **The skills act.** Each one has a job and a trigger phrase.
- **The vault remembers.** Everything lands in a labeled folder, connected to what came before.

That's the entire system. Everything else is detail.

Chapter 1 recap

● You just did this

1. Copied the `skills/` folder into your assistant's skills directory.
2. Said "Set up my second brain."
3. Answered six questions.
4. Watched your vault get built.
5. Confirmed five green checkmarks.

If you got stuck: jump to Chapter 7 (Troubleshooting). The most common issues — wrong skills folder, vault not found — each have a two-line fix there.

If it worked: next we'll tour your new brain so the folders stop being mystery drawers and start being a place you *want* to put things.

● Next

Chapter 2 — Meet your brain. We open every drawer.

Chapter 2 — Meet Your Brain

Your vault is a filing cabinet. Every drawer has a number and a label, and there's a reason for each one. Once you understand the drawers, saving and finding things becomes obvious — you'll know where something belongs before you even finish the thought.

This chapter is a tour. You don't have to act on anything — just get familiar.

The vault at a glance

```
Your Brain/
├─ 00 Inbox/           ← the "I'll sort this later" drawer
├─ 01 Personal Knowledge/ ← what you know about your world
│   ├─ People/
│   ├─ Places/
│   ├─ Routines/
│   └─ Lessons Learned/
├─ 02 Strategy/        ← where you're headed
│   ├─ Vision/
│   ├─ Goals/
│   ├─ Decision Log/
│   └─ North Star/
├─ 03 Ideas & Notes/    ← sparks, before they become projects
├─ 04 Learning/        ← what you're studying
│   ├─ Books/
│   ├─ Courses/
│   ├─ AI & Tech/
│   └─ Business/
├─ 05 AI System/       ← how your tools fit together
│   ├─ Skills/
│   ├─ Integrations/
│   └─ Architecture/
├─ 06 Session Logs/    ← a diary of every working session
├─ Templates/         ← reusable note shapes
└─ Excalidraw/        ← drawings and diagrams
```

● Why the numbers?

Numbers keep the drawers in a fixed order, top to bottom, so the most personal and frequent stuff (00–02) is always on top. The skills also find a section by its **number**, not its full name — so if you rename "01 Personal Knowledge" to "01 Company Knowledge," everything still works.

A tour of every drawer

00 Inbox — The catch-all. When something doesn't clearly fit anywhere else *yet*, it lands here so it's never lost. Think of it as the tray by your front door. You empty it later.

01 Personal Knowledge — What you know about your world. This is the richest drawer:

- **People** — clients, teammates, collaborators. What they care about, how they like to work.
- **Places** — neighborhoods, venues, regions. Local knowledge you keep relearning the hard way.
- **Routines** — your workflows and procedures. The "how we do it" that usually lives only in your head.
- **Lessons Learned** — what went right or wrong, and what to do differently next time.

02 Strategy — Where you're headed, and the choices that get you there:

- **Vision** — your long-term aspiration.
- **Goals** — time-bound objectives (this quarter, this year).
- **Decision Log** — important choices *and the reasoning behind them*, so future-you remembers *why*.
- **North Star** — your single guiding idea. (More on this in Chapter 4 — it powers the idea filter.)

● **Business owner? Rename freely**

Many business users rename "01 Personal Knowledge" to "01 Company Knowledge" and add subfolders like "Clients" or "Pricing." Go for it. The number prefix is what matters.

03 Ideas & Notes — Where ideas land *before* they're projects. A holding pen for sparks. Chapter 4's idea filter writes here every time you evaluate something.

04 Learning — What you're studying, sorted by source: **Books**, **Courses**, **AI & Tech**, and **Business**. Takeaways from a video, a framework from a course, a tool you figured out — they go here.

05 AI System — The "how my tools work" drawer. Most people touch this rarely, but it's where the brain documents its own setup: **Skills** (what each one does), **Integrations** (how tools connect), and **Architecture** (how it all fits). Your brain keeps notes on itself.

06 Session Logs — A diary. Every time you say "save to my brain," a full record of that session gets written here: what you did, what you decided, what you learned. Six months from now you can reread exactly how a decision was made.

Templates — Reusable note shapes (a daily note, a decision entry, a meeting note). You manage this drawer; the capture skill won't write into it.

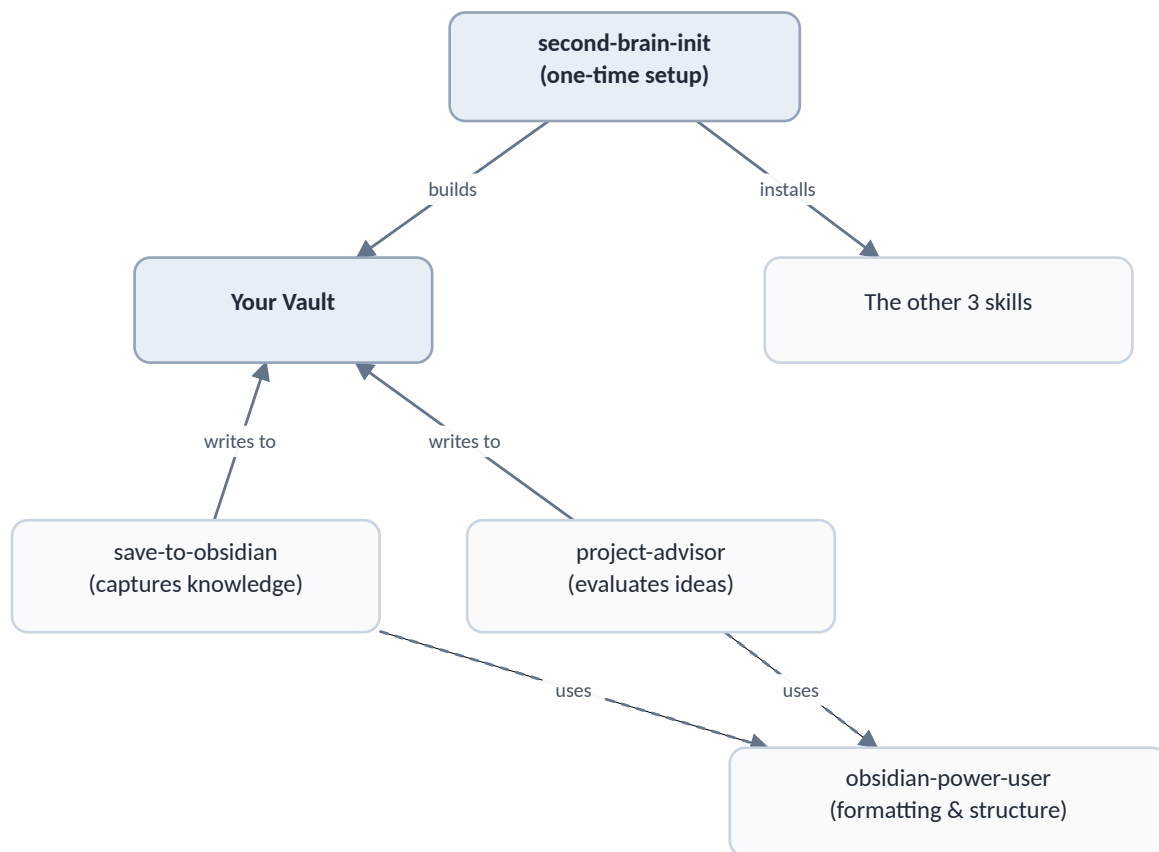
Excalidraw — Drawings and visual diagrams, if you like to think on a canvas.

● Where would this go?

"My best clients all found me through referrals." → 01 Personal Knowledge/People . "I decided to stop taking jobs more than 30 miles out." → 02 Strategy/Decision Log . "Idea: a Saturday-only premium service tier." → 03 Ideas & Notes . You'll rarely have to decide manually — the capture skill routes for you. But now you see the logic.

The four skills, and how they work together

You met the skills by name in the Introduction. Here's how they relate:



- **second-brain-init** ran once, in Chapter 1. Its job is done — you won't call it again.
- **save-to-obsidian** is your daily workhorse. It captures and files knowledge. (Chapter 3.)
- **project-advisor** is your idea filter. It scores ideas before you build them. (Chapter 4.)
- **obsidian-power-user** is the quiet expert. You rarely call it directly — the other two load it automatically so every note comes out clean, linked, and properly formatted. (Chapter 5.)

- **You only "drive" two of them**

In daily life you really only use two trigger phrases: "**save to my brain**" and "**should I do this?**" The other two skills work in the background. That's the whole interface.

CLAUDE.md — your brain's settings

Remember the six questions from setup? Their answers live in a small file called `CLAUDE.md`. Your assistant reads it at the start of **every** conversation, so it always knows:

- Your name and (optionally) your line of work.
- Your vault's name and where it lives.
- Your default language.
- Your trigger phrases.
- Whether Notion is connected.
- Your **North Star** (you fill this in after a few weeks).

You can open and edit this file any time — it's plain text. Changed your default language? Want a different trigger phrase? Edit the line, save, done. The brain picks it up next conversation.

- **Keep it short**

`CLAUDE.md` is meant to be a quick settings card, not an encyclopedia. Keep it under ~200 lines. Detailed knowledge belongs in the vault drawers, not in the settings file. A long settings file just slows every conversation down.

Obsidian basics (the optional app)

Your notes are plain text, readable anywhere. But if you install **Obsidian** (free, from obsidian.md), three features turn your folders into a real *brain*:

- **Wikilinks** — typing `[[a note's name]]` creates a clickable link between two notes. This is how ideas connect.
- **The graph** — a visual map of all your notes and their links. Watching it grow is oddly motivating.
- **Callouts** — the colored boxes you've seen in this manual (tips, warnings). They make notes easy to scan.

You don't have to learn any of this to start. The skills produce all of it *for you* — every note they write is already linked and formatted correctly. Obsidian just lets you *see* and *navigate* what the brain built.

- **Plain files, always yours**

Even with Obsidian installed, your notes never leave your computer or your cloud drive, and they're never locked in a special format. Markdown is just text. If you walked away from this kit tomorrow, every note would still open in any app.

Chapter 2 recap

- **What you now know**

- The vault has 7 numbered drawers (00-06) plus Templates and Excalidraw.
- Skills find drawers by **number**, so you can rename freely.
- You really only drive two skills day to day: capture and the idea filter.
- `CLAUDE.md` is your editable settings card.
- Obsidian is optional — it lets you see the brain, but the brain works without it.

- **Next**

Chapter 3 — the capture habit. The single most important page in this manual.

Chapter 3 — Saving Knowledge

The `save-to-obsidian` skill

If you only ever use one feature of this kit, make it this one. **Capture is the whole engine.** A second brain that never saves anything is just an empty filing cabinet. This chapter teaches you the single habit that makes everything else work.

The good news: the habit is one sentence long.

The trigger

At the end of any useful conversation with your assistant, say:

"Save to my brain."

That's it. You don't summarize. You don't sort. You don't pick a folder. You say the phrase, and the skill reads back through the whole conversation, pulls out what's worth keeping, files each piece in the right drawer, and writes a full record of the session.

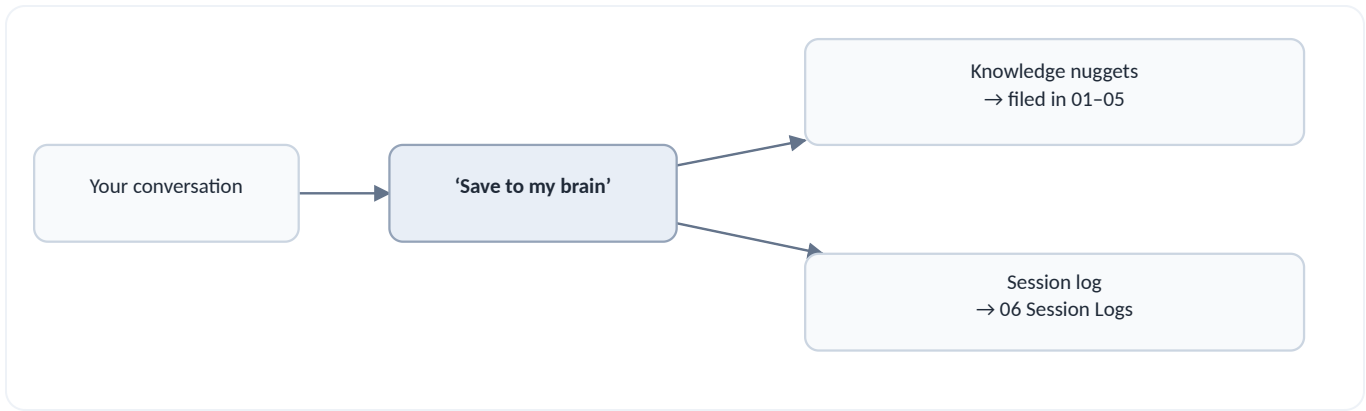
● Lots of phrasings work

"Save it," "log this," "save the session" — they all trigger it. Say it naturally. You can even change the official phrase in `CLAUDE.md` if you prefer something else.

What gets captured

When you say the phrase, the skill produces **two kinds of output** in one shot:

- 1. Knowledge nuggets.** The reusable, lasting pieces — a lesson, a decision, an idea, an insight about a person or place. Each becomes its own small note, filed in the correct drawer.
- 2. A session log.** One complete record of the whole conversation, written to `06 Session Logs/`: what you set out to do, what you decided and why, what got created, and what's still open. Even a quick session gets a log, so you can always retrace your steps.



● Why both?

The nuggets are the *lasting lessons* — the parts you'll want pulled up months later. The session log is the *full story* — useful when you need to remember exactly how or when something happened. One is the headline; the other is the article.

Where things land

You never choose the folder — the skill routes for you. Roughly:

If the conversation produced...	It files it under...
A lesson (what worked / what didn't)	01 Personal Knowledge/Lessons Learned
A decision (a choice + the why)	02 Strategy/Decision Log
An idea to explore later	03 Ideas & Notes
Insight about a person or place	01 Personal Knowledge/People or Places
A takeaway from a book/course	04 Learning/Books or Courses

A worked example

Say you spent twenty minutes talking through a job that went over budget. At the end:

You: "Save to my brain."

Here's what the skill does, in order:

1. **Re-reads the conversation** from the top.

2. **Finds the lasting pieces** — for example: a *lesson* ("always confirm surface prep before quoting"), and a *decision* ("add a 10% prep contingency to exterior quotes").
3. **Checks for duplicates** — if you already have a note on prep, it *updates* that note instead of making a second one.
4. **Writes the notes**, each properly formatted and linked to related notes.
5. **Writes the session log** to 06 Session Logs/.
6. **Shows you a summary** of exactly what it saved and where.

● What it reports back

Saved to your brain:

Knowledge nuggets:

- "Confirm Surface Prep Before Quoting" -> 01 Lessons Learned
- "Add 10% Prep Contingency to Exterior Quotes" -> 02 Decision Log

Session log:

- "Budget Overrun Review" -> 06 Session Logs

Three months later, when you're quoting a similar job and ask "what did we learn about prep?", the brain hands you that exact lesson.

It is fully bilingual

The skill works the same in English or Spanish. Open the conversation in Spanish and everything comes back in Spanish — the boxes, the headings, and the summary. The folder names and a few technical tags stay in English (that's what the tools read), but everything you see is in your language. If you think in Spanglish, talk in Spanglish — the skill preserves your voice instead of flattening it into one language.

What it will NOT do

Good capture is as much about what it *skips* as what it saves:

- **No duplicates.** It checks first and updates the existing note instead of piling on copies.
- **No junk.** Pure troubleshooting steps, file paths, and one-off details go in the session log — not as permanent "knowledge."
- **No transcript dumps.** It extracts the *lesson*, not the entire back-and-forth.
- **No mess in your folders.** Every note is filed in exactly one place, linked to related notes.

● One vault rule worth knowing

The kit's #1 hygiene rule is **no duplicates**. If you ever feel like the same idea exists in two notes, just ask: "Are there any duplicate notes about X?" The brain will find and merge them. A clean vault is a useful vault.

Make it a habit

The skill is effortless. The *remembering to use it* is the only real work. A few ways to make it automatic:

- **End-of-session reflex.** Treat "save to my brain" like locking the door on your way out. Last thing, every time.
- **After anything you'd hate to lose.** A good decision, a hard-won lesson, a client detail — capture it while it's fresh.
- **Even for "small" sessions.** The session log is cheap and the payoff is future context. When in doubt, save.

● A 7-day starter challenge

For one week, end every work conversation with "save to my brain." At the end of the week, open 06 Session Logs/ and read back. You'll see your brain has quietly become a journal of your week — and you'll never want to stop.

When the vault isn't connected

Occasionally the assistant can't see your vault (for example, you didn't mount the folder in your tool that day). If that happens, the skill **tells you** and asks you to grant access — it will **never** dump your notes into some random folder as a workaround. If you see that message, point it at your vault and try again. (Chapter 7 has the exact steps.)

Chapter 3 recap

● The one habit

End any useful conversation with "**save to my brain.**" The skill captures the lasting lessons, writes a full session log, files everything correctly, avoids duplicates, and shows you exactly what it saved.

That's capture. It's the input side of your brain — how knowledge gets *in*. Next we cover the decision side: how your brain helps you choose what's actually worth building, so you stop pouring time into the wrong projects.

- **Next**

Chapter 4 — the idea filter. Before you build anything, run it through this.

Chapter 4 — Deciding What to Build

The project-advisor skill

Chapter 3 was about getting knowledge *in*. This chapter is about using your brain to make a *better decision* — specifically, the decision that quietly drains the most time from busy people: **"Should I build this thing I just thought of?"**

Ideas are cheap and constant. Some are gold. Some are fine but mistimed. Some shouldn't be built at all. The project-advisor skill is a quick, honest filter that catches every idea *before* it eats your week.

Why you need an idea filter

Every "yes" to a new project is a silent "no" to something else — your time, your focus, the project you were already doing. The problem is that ideas feel exciting in the moment, and excitement is a terrible judge of whether something's worth building *now*.

● The cost of the half-built project

The most expensive thing in any business isn't a project that fails — it's the pile of half-finished projects that drained attention and never shipped. The filter exists to keep that pile small.

This skill doesn't kill your ideas. It *scores* them, and even the ones it says "not now" to are saved in your vault so you can reopen them when the timing is right.

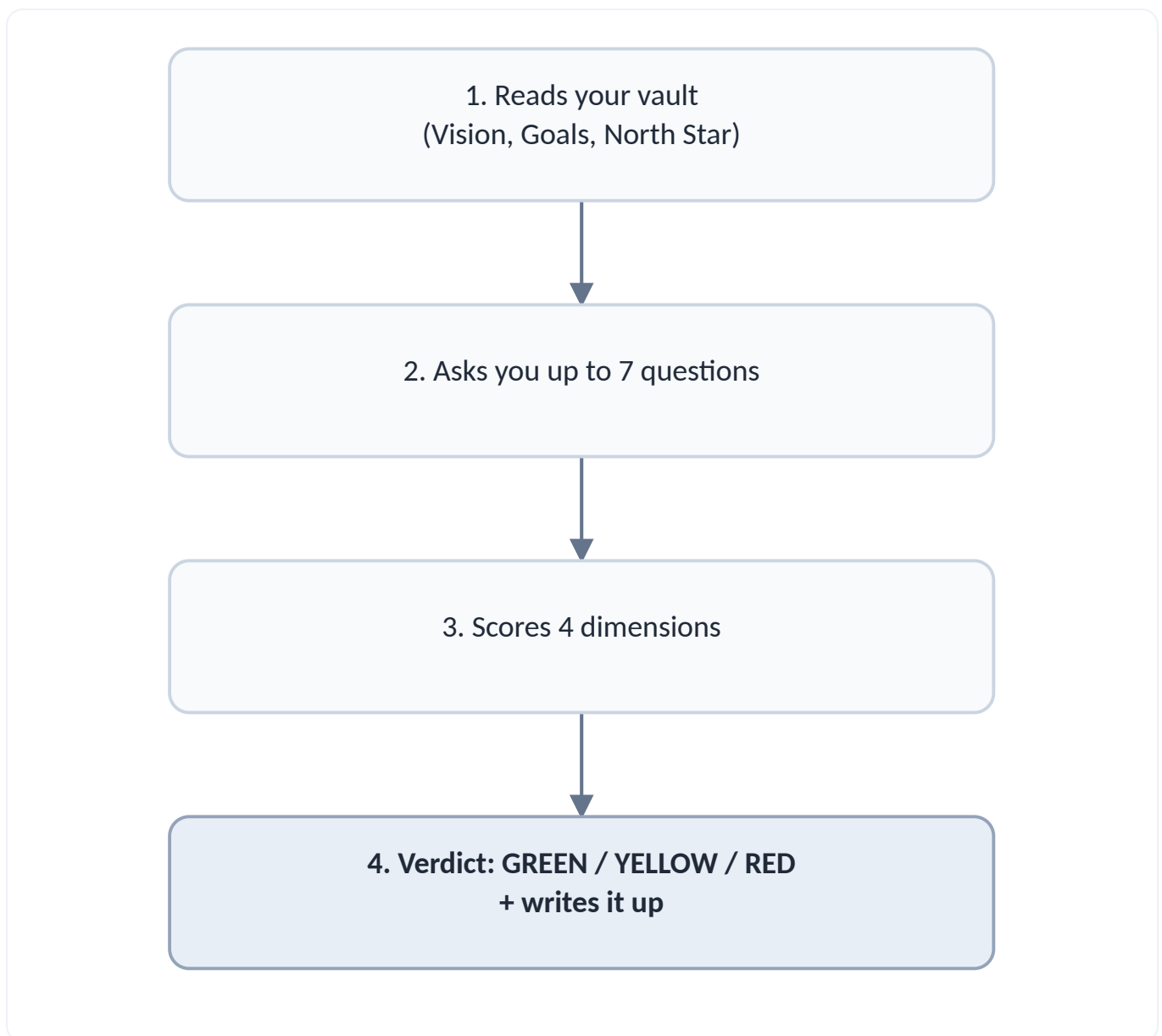
The trigger

When you have an idea and want a real evaluation, say:

"Should I do this?" / "Should I build this?"

Then describe the idea. The skill takes it from there.

How it works — four phases



First, it **reads your strategy drawers silently** — your Vision, your Goals, your North Star — so it's giving you advice grounded in *your* priorities, not generic tips. Then it asks questions, scores the idea, and gives a clear verdict with the reasoning written out.

The 7 questions

It asks these one at a time. Each answer shapes the next. Here's what each one is really getting at:

#	The question	What it's really asking
1	In one sentence, what is this?	Can you say it clearly? Fuzzy ideas aren't ready.
2	What problem does it solve, and whose?	Is there a real problem, or just novelty?
3	How is it handled today?	Does it replace a painful manual task (high value) or invent new work?
4	What does success look like in 90 days?	If you can't name a number, it's not ready.
5	What will it cost to build?	Time, money, tools — a rough estimate is fine.
6	If you build this, what <i>doesn't</i> get built?	The most important question. Every yes is a no.
7	Which part of your life/work does it strengthen most?	Only asked if it's still unclear.

● **Question 6 is the one that hurts**

"What are you saying no to?" is uncomfortable on purpose. If building this idea means dropping something you already committed to, the filter wants you to see that trade *before* you start, not three weeks in.

The scorecard

The skill scores your idea on **four dimensions**, each from 1 to 10. The dimensions are weighted — some matter more than others:

Dimension	Weight	What it measures
Systemization	25%	Does this turn repeated manual work into a reusable system?
North Star alignment	30%	Does it move you toward your guiding vision?
Revenue / Cost impact	25%	Does it make money, save money, or prevent costly mistakes?
Timing	20%	Is <i>now</i> the right moment, given your capacity?

The **North Star** carries the most weight (30%) because it's *your* guiding vision — the thing you decided everything should point toward. **Timing** carries the least (20%) because a great idea that's slightly early can be reopened later; that's why even "no" ideas get saved.

● What's a "North Star"?

It's the one long-term outcome you're really building toward — the sentence that, if everything else is noise, still rings true. You set it in `CLAUDE.md` after a few weeks of using your brain. Until you've named it, the skill uses a generic "North Star alignment" and nudges you to define yours.

How the math works

Each dimension gets a 1–10 score, then multiplied by its weight, then added up:

```
Final = (Systemization × 0.25)
        + (North Star   × 0.30)
        + (Revenue/Cost × 0.25)
        + (Timing       × 0.20)
```

The skill **always shows you the math** — not just the final number — so you can see *why* it landed where it did, and push back if a score feels off.

The verdict

The weighted score maps to one of three colors:

Score	Verdict	Meaning
7.5 – 10	● GREEN — Build it	Strong fit. Move into execution.
5.0 – 7.4	● YELLOW — Refine first	Has merit, but something's missing. The skill tells you <i>exactly</i> what to fix before re-scoring.
0 – 4.9	● RED — Shelf it	Not now. Saved in your vault with the reasoning, so you can reopen it if things change.

Two special rules keep the verdict honest:

● The override and the veto

- **Override:** if North Star scores 9 or 10 *and* the total is at least 5.0, it bumps to GREEN. Vision-critical ideas don't wait.
- **Veto:** if Timing scores 1 or 2, the verdict is capped at YELLOW no matter how high everything else is. Wrong-time ideas are not build-now ideas.

A worked example

You: "Should I do this? I want to build a weekly email digest that auto-summarizes everything new in my industry."

The skill silently reads your vault and notices your North Star mentions "stay current without doom-scrolling," and your latest session log shows you're mid-launch on something else this week. Then it asks its questions, and scores:

● The scorecard it produces

Dimension	Score	Weight	Weighted
Systemization	8/10	25%	2.00
North Star	9/10	30%	2.70
Revenue/Cost	4/10	25%	1.00
Timing	3/10	20%	0.60
TOTAL			6.30 / 10

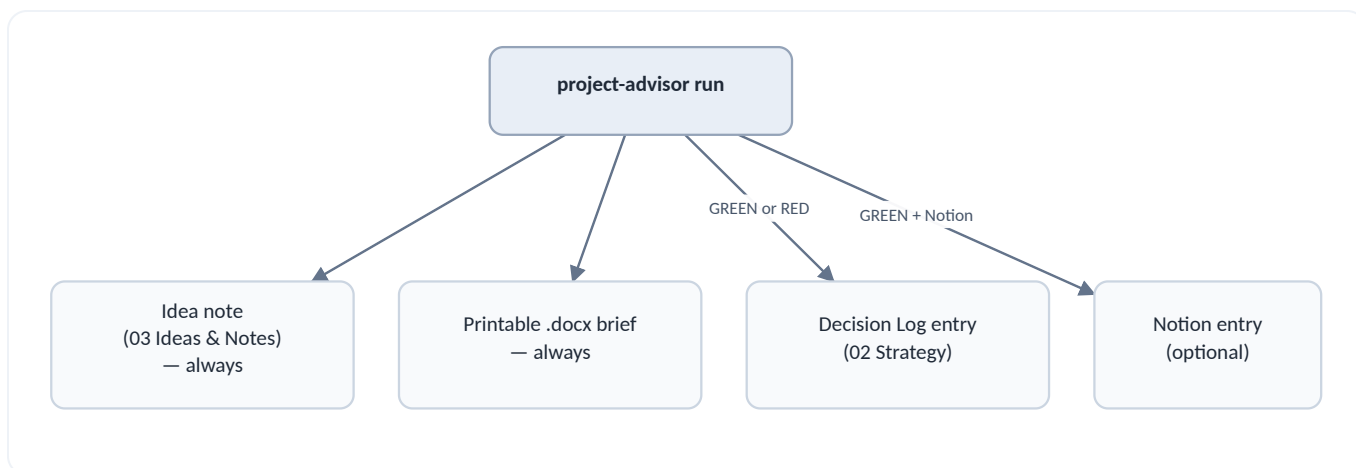
Raw verdict: ● YELLOW (6.3). **Override check:** North Star = 9 and total $\geq 5.0 \rightarrow$ bumps to ● GREEN. **Veto check:** Timing = 3 (not 1-2) $\rightarrow$ no veto. **Final:** ● GREEN — but the write-up flags that timing is weak, so the "next steps" say *start after this week's launch ships*.

Notice what happened: the idea is genuinely aligned with your vision (North Star 9), so the override pushed it to GREEN — but the skill is honest that the *timing* is poor and tells you to wait a week. That's the difference between a filter that just says yes/no and one that actually advises you.

What you get out of it

Every run produces written output so the thinking is never lost:

- **An idea note** in 03 Ideas & Notes/ — the full evaluation, every verdict (green, yellow, or red).
- **A decision log entry** in 02 Strategy/Decision Log/ — but only for GREEN or RED (a real go / no-go). YELLOW is a "not yet," so it doesn't clutter your decision log.
- **A printable brief** (a .docx document) you can read, share, or print.
- **(Optional) a Notion entry** — only if you turned Notion on during setup *and* the verdict is GREEN.



● Shelved isn't deleted

A RED verdict doesn't throw your idea away — it parks it with a note about *what would need to change* for it to come back (e.g., "revisit after Q3," or "when you have a spare 10 hours a week"). Your brain becomes a place where good-but-early ideas wait safely instead of getting forgotten.

When to use it

Run the filter when:

- You catch yourself about to start building something new.
- You're torn between two possible projects and need to pick one.
- An idea keeps nagging at you and you want an honest read on whether it's worth it.

Don't run it for tasks you've already committed to, or tiny things — it's for *projects*, the kind that cost real time. And remember: it evaluates **before** you build. Once it says GREEN, you move on to actually doing the work.

Chapter 4 recap

● The idea filter in one breath

Say "**should I do this?**", describe the idea, answer up to 7 questions, and get a ● / ● / ● verdict — backed by your own North Star, with the math shown and the write-up saved.

You now have both halves of a thinking brain: **capture** (Chapter 3) puts knowledge in, and the **idea filter** (Chapter 4) helps you act on it wisely. The next chapter covers the quiet skill that makes all of this come out clean — and the handful of things you can ask it for directly.

- **Next**

Chapter 5 — power moves. The skill that works behind the scenes — and what you can ask it to do on purpose.

Chapter 5 — Power Moves

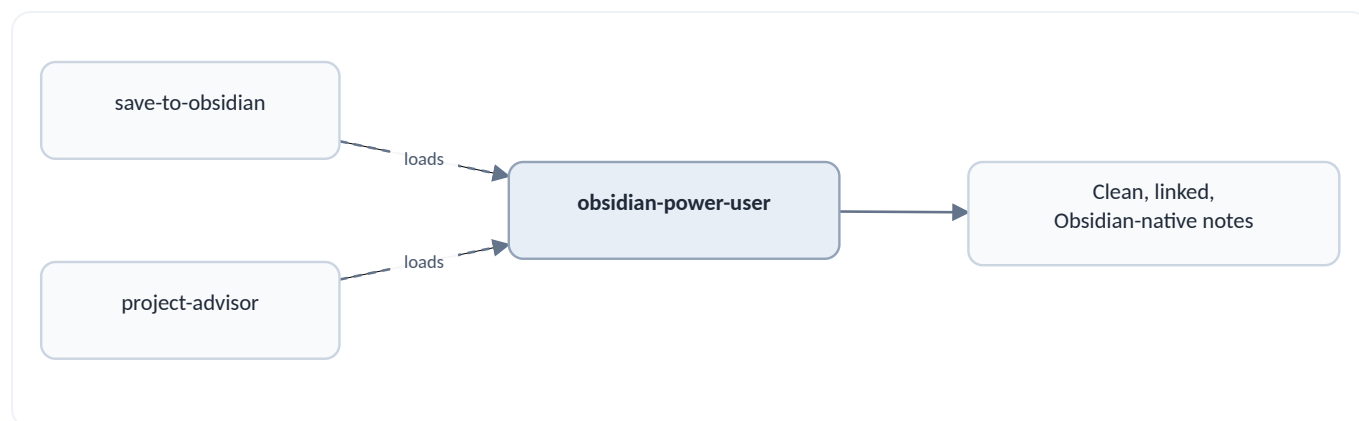
The `obsidian-power-user` skill

This is the skill you'll use the *most* and *think about* the *least*. It's the quiet craftsman of your brain — the one that makes sure every note comes out clean, linked, and properly structured, without you ever asking.

This chapter is short on purpose. You don't have to drive this skill. But knowing what it can do unlocks a few genuinely useful "power moves" for when you want more than a plain note.

The skill you rarely call directly

Here's the key idea: whenever `save-to-obsidian` or `project-advisor` writes to your vault, they **automatically load** `obsidian-power-user` first. That's why your captured notes already have proper titles, links between related notes, colored callout boxes, and tidy formatting — you never asked for any of it, but it's there.



● Think of it like a spell-checker

You don't open your spell-checker and ask it to work — it just runs while you type. `obsidian-power-user` is the same: it runs in the background whenever the brain writes, so the output is always polished.

What you CAN ask it for

When you *do* call it on purpose, it's a full Obsidian expert. The four most useful things to ask for:

1. **A template.** A reusable note shape — a daily note, a meeting note, a weekly review. Ask once and reuse it forever.
2. **A canvas.** A visual board where ideas are cards you can arrange and connect freely — great for planning or mapping something out spatially.

3. A dashboard or "Map of Content" (MOC). An index note that gathers links to everything on a topic. Your vault's table of contents for, say, "all my pricing notes."

4. A clean note from messy input. Paste rough notes and ask it to turn them into a properly formatted, linked vault note.

- **You don't need the jargon**

Words like "canvas," "MOC," "Dataview," and "Templater" are Obsidian terms. You don't have to learn them. Just describe what you *want* — "a visual board to plan my week," "an index of all my client notes" — and the skill picks the right tool.

Copy-paste prompts that just work

Here are prompts you can paste as-is. Swap the bracketed parts for your own.

- **Make a weekly review template**

"Create a weekly review template for my brain — sections for wins, what I learned, open decisions, and next week's focus."

- **Build a topic index**

"Make a Map of Content that links all my notes about [pricing]. Put it in 02 Strategy."

- **Plan something visually**

"Create a canvas to plan my [Q3 hiring]. One card per step, connected in order."

- **Clean up rough notes**

"Here are my messy notes from today's meeting — turn them into a clean note in 01 Personal Knowledge and link anything relevant." (*then paste your notes*)

- **It always produces the real thing**

Ask for a template and you get a complete, ready-to-use template file — not a description of how to make one. Ask for a canvas and you get a working canvas. This skill never hands you homework; it hands you the finished item.

When to reach for it on purpose

Most days, you won't — capture and the idea filter cover normal use. Reach for `obsidian-power-user` directly when you want to:

- **Set up a reusable structure** (a template you'll fill in repeatedly).
- **See something spatially** (a canvas/board instead of a list).
- **Organize an area that's grown** (an index/MOC once you have lots of notes on one topic).
- **Tidy up** (turn a pile of rough notes into proper, linked notes).

● Bilingual here too

Ask in Spanish and your notes come back with Spanish headings and callouts. The technical bits Obsidian needs (a few tags and settings) stay in English, but everything you read is in your language.

A note on Obsidian features

This skill knows essentially *all* of Obsidian — links, embeds, callouts, templates, canvases, databases, queries, even custom styling. You will never need most of it. That's fine. It's there so that as you grow more comfortable, your brain can grow with you. You can ask "what else can you help me do in Obsidian?" any time and it'll show you options at your level.

● Don't over-engineer early

A common trap is spending your first week building elaborate dashboards instead of *capturing knowledge*. Resist it. The brain gets valuable from the **habit** (Chapter 3), not from fancy structure. Add power moves once you have notes worth organizing.

Chapter 5 recap

● Power moves in one breath

`obsidian-power-user` runs **automatically** behind your other skills, keeping every note clean and linked. Call it **on purpose** when you want a template, a visual canvas, a topic index, or to tidy rough notes — just describe what you want in plain language.

You've now met all four skills:

- `second-brain-init` built your brain (once).
- `save-to-obsidian` captures knowledge (daily).

- **project-advisor** filters ideas (when you have one).
- **obsidian-power-user** keeps it all clean (quietly).

The remaining chapters are about *living* with your brain: the small weekly habit that keeps it healthy, fixes for the few things that can go wrong, and where you can take it next.

- **Next**

Chapter 6 — keeping it healthy. Five minutes a week.

Chapter 6 — Keeping It Healthy

A second brain is a living thing. It doesn't need much maintenance — but it needs a little, and the little it needs is what separates a brain that gets more useful every month from a junk drawer that fills with disconnected notes.

The whole maintenance routine is about **five minutes a week**.

The weekly rhythm

Once a week — many people do it Monday morning or Friday afternoon — update one short file: **CURRENT-CONTEXT.md**. This is the rolling summary your brain reads first in every conversation. Keeping it current is the single highest-value habit after capture.

It has four small sections. Just refresh them:

- **Active projects** — what you're working on right now.
- **This week's focus** — the one or two things that matter most.
- **Open questions** — things you're chewing on but haven't resolved.
- **Recent decisions** — links to anything you decided this week.

● Make it a calendar event

Put a recurring 5-minute "update my brain" block on your calendar. Open **CURRENT-CONTEXT.md**, freshen the four sections, save. That's it. You can even ask your assistant: "Help me update my current context for this week."

● What it looks like updated

This week's focus: Close the Maple St. estimate · finish hiring the new crew lead. **Open questions:** Should we raise exterior prices 8% for summer? **Recent decisions:** [[2026-05-25 Decision — Drop jobs over 30 miles]]

Vault hygiene rules

The skills follow these automatically, but knowing them helps you keep things clean when you add notes by hand:

1. **No duplicates.** One note per topic. If two notes cover the same ground, merge them. (Ask: "Find duplicate notes about X.")

2. **Link everything.** Every note should connect to at least two others. Isolated notes are dead notes — they never resurface when you need them.
3. **Knowledge only.** The vault is for lasting knowledge and session logs — not temporary files, drafts, or scratch work.
4. **No "version 2" files.** Edit the original note instead of making `Note v2` . One living note beats five stale copies.
5. **Templates stay in `Templates/` ; drawings stay in `Excalidraw/` .** Keep the special folders for their purpose.

● The one that bites people

Duplicates. It's tempting to just write a new note each time a topic comes up. Resist it. A monthly "find and merge duplicates" sweep keeps your brain sharp. Ask your assistant to do it — it's good at finding them.

A simple monthly check

Once a month, spend ten minutes asking your brain a few health questions:

- "Are there any duplicate notes I should merge?"
- "Which notes have no links to anything else?" (then ask it to connect them)
- "What's been sitting in `00 Inbox` that I should file?"

That's the entire maintenance program. Weekly context update, the hygiene rules running in the background, and a ten-minute monthly tidy.

Customizing `CLAUDE.md` as you go

Your brain learns you over time, and `CLAUDE.md` is where that learning gets recorded. Update it whenever something changes:

- **Name your North Star** once you know it. This sharpens the idea filter (Chapter 4) dramatically — it's the most valuable single edit you'll make.
- **Add the people who matter** — recurring clients, your team — so the brain understands references to them.
- **Add your own vocabulary** — nicknames, project codenames, shorthand you use.
- **Change a trigger phrase** if a different one feels more natural.

- **Keep it lean**

`CLAUDE.md` is a settings card, not a knowledge dump. Keep it under ~200 lines. When something grows into real detail, move it into a vault note and just *link* to it from `CLAUDE.md`. Long settings files slow down every conversation.

Chapter 6 recap

- **The maintenance routine**

- **Weekly (5 min):** update `CURRENT-CONTEXT.md`.
- **Monthly (10 min):** merge duplicates, connect orphan notes, empty the Inbox.
- **As needed:** keep `CLAUDE.md` current — especially your North Star.

A healthy brain compounds. Each week of small upkeep makes every future conversation a little smarter. Next, the short chapter you'll come back to whenever something doesn't behave: troubleshooting.

- **Next**

Chapter 7 — troubleshooting & FAQ. The fixes for the few things that go wrong.

Chapter 7 — Troubleshooting & FAQ

Almost nothing goes wrong with this kit, because there's so little to break. But here are the handful of things people occasionally hit, each with a quick fix.

"The brain can't find my vault."

This is the most common one, and it's almost always because the vault folder isn't *connected* to your assistant in that session.

Fix: make sure your vault folder is mounted or shared with your assistant (in Cowork, select/grant access to the folder). Then try again. The brain will **never** dump notes into a random place as a workaround — if it can't see the vault, it stops and asks. That's by design.

"It didn't trigger when I said the phrase."

Fix: say it a little more directly — "Save this to my brain." If it still doesn't, your assistant may not have loaded the skills folder. Re-check Chapter 1, Step 1 (the skills must be in the right folder for your assistant), and start a fresh conversation.

"It answered in the wrong language."

Fix: just tell it — "answer in English" or "responde en español." To change it permanently, open `CLAUDE.md` and edit the language line. Every skill is fully bilingual; this is only ever a default setting, never a limitation.

"Do I have to use Notion?"

No. Notion is optional and only touches one skill (`project-advisor`). If you said "No" at setup, everything works perfectly and saves to your vault. If you said yes but changed your mind, set `NOTION_ENABLED` to off in `CLAUDE.md` .

"I ran setup twice."

No harm done. `second-brain-init` detects that your brain already exists and *stops* — it asks whether you want to keep what you have, change specific answers, or start over. It never silently overwrites your vault. Just choose "keep what I have."

"I don't have Obsidian installed."

That's fine — your brain still works. The notes are plain text files you can open in any editor. Install Obsidian (free, from obsidian.md) whenever you want the graph view and clickable links. Nothing about capture or the idea filter depends on the app.

Quick FAQ

● Short answers

Will this work on my phone? Your *notes* sync to your phone if you chose iCloud/Dropbox at setup.

Running the skills happens wherever you use your assistant.

Can I rename the folders? Yes — keep the number prefix (01, 02...) and the skills still find everything.

Is my data private? Yes. Everything stays in your own vault, on your computer or your cloud drive. Nothing is locked in a special format.

What if I stop using the kit? You keep every note. They're plain markdown — yours forever.

Can I share this kit? Yes — it's meant to be shared freely (see Chapter 8).

● When in doubt, ask the brain

Your assistant can troubleshoot itself. "Why didn't my save work?" or "Is my vault connected?" usually gets you a straight answer and a fix faster than this page.

● Next

Chapter 8 — growing your brain. Where you can take this next.

Chapter 8 — Growing Your Brain

You started this manual with a shoebox of scattered knowledge. You're ending it with a real system: a vault that captures what you learn, files it correctly, connects it, and helps you decide what to build next. That's a genuine head start most people never get.

So where does it go from here?

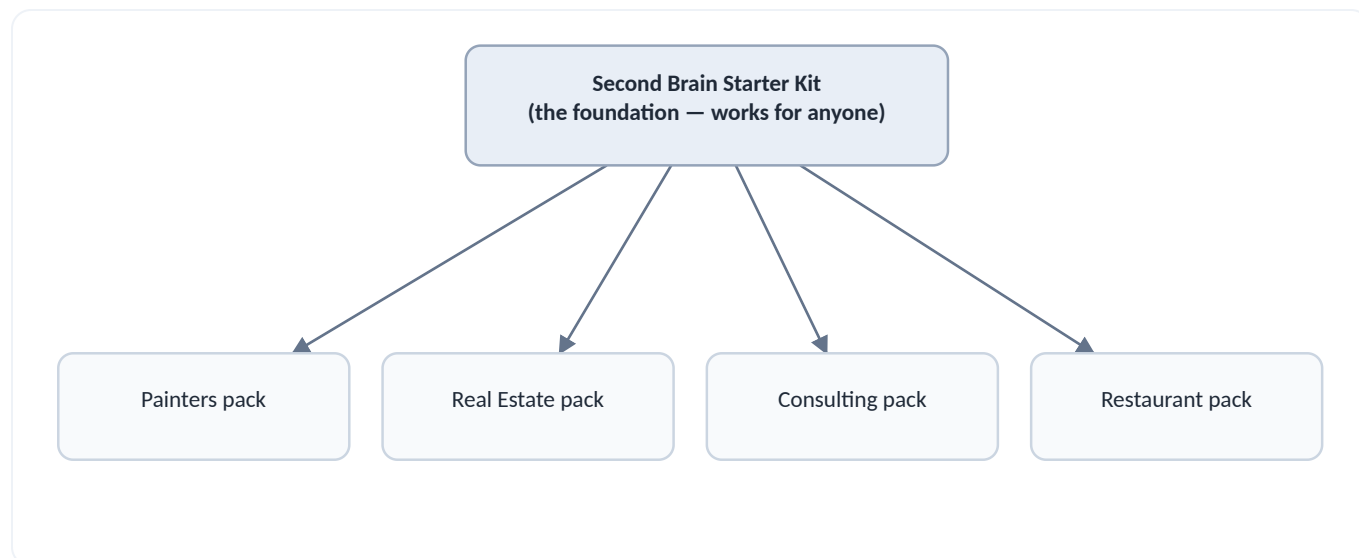
It grows with use, not with effort

The most important thing to understand: **your brain gets better simply because you use it**. Every "save to my brain" adds a note. Every note links to others. Every week of context updates teaches it more about you. You don't have to do anything special — the value compounds on its own, as a byproduct of the two small habits in Chapters 3 and 6.

Give it three months of light, consistent use and you'll have something genuinely hard to replace: a searchable record of your decisions, your lessons, and your thinking.

Vertical packs — making it fit your trade

This kit is the **foundation** — a brain that works for anyone. On top of it, you can build a *vertical pack*: a set of extra skills and note structures tuned to a specific kind of work. The same foundation, specialized.



A **Painters** pack might add estimating notes and crew knowledge. A **Real Estate** pack might add property and client-pipeline structures. A **Consulting** pack might add client and proposal templates. Same brain underneath — each one just teaches it the language of a trade.

- **You don't need a pack to start**

The foundation alone is a complete, useful brain. Vertical packs are a *later* upgrade, not a requirement.

Use the base kit for a few weeks first — you'll discover what your own trade actually needs, and that tells you what a pack should contain.

Share it

This kit was built to be **shared freely with family and friends**. If someone you know is drowning in scattered notes, hand them the folder and this manual. Setup takes ten minutes, and they'll have a working brain the same day. Remix it, extend it, build a pack on it — that's the whole point.

- **The best way to learn it is to teach it**

Walking a friend through setup will cement your own understanding better than reading any chapter twice. And now there are two of you with second brains.

A final word

You don't have to be technical to think clearly, decide well, and remember what matters. That was never the hard part. The hard part was having a *place* for it all — and now you do.

Start small. Capture one conversation today. Update your context this week. Run one idea through the filter when the next one hits you. The brain takes care of the rest, and it gets a little smarter every time you use it.

Welcome to your second brain.

- **Your first three moves**

1. **Today:** have a normal work conversation, then say "*save to my brain.*"
2. **This week:** spend 5 minutes filling in `CURRENT-CONTEXT.md`.
3. **Next idea you get:** say "*should I do this?*" and let the filter weigh in.

